In the Beginning Was the Word

The Eternal Logos Revealed in Genesis 1:1–3 and John 1:1–5

I. Introduction: Two Beginnings, One Eternal Truth

The opening verses of Genesis and the Gospel of John are among the most profound declarations in all of Scripture. Written centuries apart, they begin with nearly identical words: *"In the beginning."* Yet while Genesis introduces the creation of the universe, John reaches beyond creation itself to reveal the eternal existence of the One through whom all things were made.

Genesis 1:1 declares, *"In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth."* John 1:1 declares, *"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God."*

These statements are not competing explanations of creation. They are complementary revelations of the same divine reality. Genesis establishes that Elohim is the Creator of all things. John reveals that the eternal Word, the Logos, was with God before creation and was Himself God.

Throughout the opening chapter of Genesis, we encounter the repeated declaration, "And God said." With each divine command, creation responds. Light appears, the heavens are formed, the waters are gathered, and life comes forth. But what is the deeper significance of those words? Genesis reveals the sovereign power of Elohim speaking creation into existence, while John provides the fuller revelation of the divine Person through whom that creative work was accomplished. When John declares, "In the beginning was the Word," he deliberately directs our attention back to Genesis. The Greek word *Logos*, translated "Word," identifies the eternal Son, who was with God, who was God, and through whom all things were made (John 1:1–3). What Genesis reveals through the creative commands of Elohim, John illuminates through the eternal Logos.

The connection becomes even more remarkable when we consider Genesis 1:3: *"And God said, Let there be light: and there was light."* John identifies the Logos as the source of life and the light of humanity, declaring that the light shines in darkness and the darkness has not overcome it.

Thesis Statement: Genesis 1:1–3 and John 1:1–5 reveal a unified biblical truth: the eternal Logos, who was with God and was Himself God before creation, is the divine Agent through whom all things came into existence. Genesis reveals God's creative Word bringing light into darkness, while John identifies that Word as the eternal Son, the source of all life and the true Light of humanity. Together, these passages establish the continuity between creation and redemption, revealing that Jesus Christ, the Word made flesh, is both the Creator of the universe and the Redeemer of fallen humanity.

II. Genesis 1:1 — The Beginning of Creation

The Bible opens with a declaration of extraordinary simplicity and theological depth:

"In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth." (Genesis 1:1)

The Hebrew expression *Bereshit bara Elohim* establishes three fundamental truths: creation had a beginning, God existed before that beginning, and the universe owes its existence to Him.

Genesis does not attempt to explain God's origin. It assumes His eternal existence. Before the heavens and the earth existed, before matter and space formed the universe we know, Elohim already existed. Even the succession of events by which we measure time belongs to the created order rather than to the eternal nature of God.

The Hebrew verb *bara*, translated "created," describes the creative action of Elohim. The opening declaration attributes the existence of the heavens and the earth entirely to God's sovereign initiative. Genesis presents the universe as the result of divine action rather than an independent or self-originating reality.

The opening verse therefore establishes a distinction between the eternal Creator and the created order. Everything that begins to exist belongs to creation; Elohim stands before and beyond it.

This distinction becomes essential when we turn to John's Gospel, because John identifies the Logos as existing before anything was created.

III. John 1:1–2 — The Word Who Already Existed

John deliberately begins his Gospel with language that recalls Genesis:

"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God." (John 1:1)

The Greek opening, *En archē ēn ho Logos*, closely parallels the opening words of Genesis in the Greek Septuagint, *En archē epoiēsen ho Theos*.

Yet John introduces a remarkable distinction.

Genesis begins at the moment creation comes into existence. John begins by identifying the One who already existed when that moment arrived. Genesis directs our attention to the beginning of all created things; John directs our attention to the eternal Word who had no beginning. The two accounts meet at creation, but John reveals the divine Person through whom that creation was accomplished.

The Greek verb *ēn*, translated "was," describes the Word as already existing when creation began. This becomes particularly significant when contrasted with *egeneto*, the verb John uses in verse 3 to describe everything that came into existence. John thus distinguishes the continuing existence of the Logos from the beginning of created things. The Word did not come into being at creation; He already existed.

The Logos belongs on the Creator's side of that distinction, not the creature's.

John then makes three declarations concerning the Word.

First, "In the beginning was the Word." The Logos existed when creation began. His existence did not originate with the universe.

Second, "The Word was with God." The Greek expression *pros ton Theon* conveys a relationship between the Logos and God. The Word is personally distinguishable from the One with whom He exists.

Third, "The Word was God." John identifies the Logos as possessing the divine nature. The Greek phrase *kai theos ēn ho logos* emphasizes the deity of the Word without identifying Him as the same Person as the Father. John does not identify the Logos as the Father, nor does he describe

Him as a secondary deity. He affirms the full deity of the Word while distinguishing Him personally from the One with whom He eternally existed.

John reinforces this truth in verse 2:

"The same was in the beginning with God." (John 1:2)

Before describing the Logos as the Agent of creation, John deliberately reaffirms His eternal relationship with God. The One through whom all things were made was already with God when creation began. Thus, the creative work of the Logos proceeds from His eternal divine existence, not from any beginning of His own.

These declarations provide the foundation for understanding the eternal relationship between the Father and the Son.

Genesis reveals one eternal Creator. John reveals that the Logos was eternally with God and was Himself God.

IV. Genesis 1:2–3 — Creation Through the Spoken Word

Genesis continues:

"And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters." (Genesis 1:2)

The Hebrew expression ruach Elohim is traditionally translated "the Spirit of God," although ruach can also mean wind or breath. Its Greek counterpart, pneuma, likewise carries the meanings of spirit, wind, and breath. In the New Testament, Pneuma Hagion refers to the Holy Spirit. This linguistic connection is significant: Genesis introduces the Spirit of God moving upon the waters, while the fuller revelation of Scripture identifies the Holy Spirit as the divine Person active in creation and throughout God's redemptive purposes.

This passage provides an important connection to the later revelation of the Holy Spirit's participation in the divine work of creation.

Genesis then records:

"And God said, Let there be light: and there was light." (Genesis 1:3)

The Hebrew expression *wayyōmer Elohim* means "And God said."

Throughout the creation account, this expression introduces God's creative commands. Elohim speaks, and the created order responds.

There is no struggle between competing powers. No independent force resists His authority. The divine command is sufficient to accomplish His purpose.

Psalm 33:6 reinforces this truth:

"By the word of the LORD were the heavens made; and all the host of them by the breath of his mouth."

Psalm 33:9 continues:

"For he spake, and it was done; he commanded, and it stood fast."

The Hebrew word translated *word* in Psalm 33:6 is *dabar*. It refers to speech, a word, or a declared matter and can emphasize the effective power of God's command.

Although the Hebrew *dabar* and the Greek *Logos* are not identical in every nuance of meaning, both can express the effective power of God's Word. John's revelation does not depend upon equating the two terms mechanically, but upon his explicit declaration that all things were made through the eternal Logos.

Genesis does not explicitly identify God's spoken Word as a distinct divine Person. It presents creation as the result of God's sovereign speech.

John, however, reveals that the eternal Logos was the divine Agent through whom creation came into existence.

Genesis 1:2 also introduces the Spirit of God moving upon the face of the waters. Thus, the opening creation account presents Elohim as Creator, His Spirit active in creation, and His sovereign Word bringing forth light. Although Genesis does not explicitly articulate the doctrine of the Trinity, the fuller revelation of the New Testament identifies the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit as participating in the one divine work of creation.

What Genesis reveals through the creative speech of Elohim, John more fully explains by identifying the eternal Logos as the divine Agent of creation.

V. John 1:3 — All Things Were Made Through Him

John declares:

"All things were made by him; and without him was not any thing made that was made." (John 1:3)

This statement is comprehensive.

The Greek expression *panta di' autou egeneto* means that all things came into being through Him.

John then reinforces the declaration negatively: without the Logos, not one thing that came into existence was made.

The implication is unavoidable. If everything that came into existence was created through the Logos, the Logos Himself cannot belong to the category of created things.

He is not the first creature. He is not an exalted angel. He is not a being who came into existence before the remainder of creation.

He is the eternal divine Agent through whom all created things came into being.

This truth is reinforced by Paul in Colossians 1:16–17:

"For by him were all things created, that are in heaven, and that are in earth, visible and invisible... And he is before all things, and by him all things consist."

Hebrews 1:2 likewise declares that God made the worlds through His Son.

John later reinforces the same truth:

"He was in the world, and the world was made by him, and the world knew him not." (John 1:10)

This verse provides a direct connection between the Logos as Creator and His subsequent entrance into the world He created.

These passages establish that the Logos is not merely associated with creation. All created things owe their existence to Him.

Genesis declares that Elohim created the heavens and the earth. John identifies the eternal Word as the One through whom that creation was accomplished.

There is no contradiction between the two accounts. They describe the same divine work from different perspectives.

VI. Genesis 1:3 and John 1:4–5 — Light, Life, and Darkness

The first creative command recorded in Genesis is:

"Let there be light: and there was light." (Genesis 1:3)

Before the formation of the sun, moon, and stars described on the fourth day, light appears at the command of Elohim.

The passage establishes that light itself is subject to the Creator's authority.

John develops the theme:

"In him was life; and the life was the light of men. And the light shineth in darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not." (John 1:4–5)

John's language recalls the creation account, but his emphasis moves beyond physical illumination.

In Genesis, light enters a world described as dark.

In John, the Logos possesses life in Himself, and that life is the light of humanity.

The distinction is significant. Genesis describes the beginning of physical light within creation. John describes the eternal source of life and the revelation of divine truth to humanity.

The Greek word *zōē*, translated *life*, becomes a central theme throughout John's Gospel. It refers not merely to biological existence but, in John's theological development, to the life that comes from God and is made available through Jesus Christ.

The Greek word *phōs*, translated *light*, similarly develops beyond physical illumination to describe divine revelation, truth, and the life-giving presence of Christ.

The Greek Septuagint uses *phōs* in Genesis 1:3 for the light brought forth by God's command. John employs the same word in describing the light associated with the Logos. This shared vocabulary reinforces the literary and theological connection between the two passages.

John 1:5 declares that the light shines in darkness and that the darkness *"comprehended it not."*

The Greek verb *katalambanō* can mean either to comprehend or to overcome. John's language may intentionally convey both ideas: fallen humanity fails to recognize the Light, while the darkness remains powerless to extinguish it. Although interpreters differ over which meaning John principally intended, both themes are developed within his Gospel.

The theological connection is profound.

The One through whom physical light first appeared is Himself the source of the spiritual light that fallen humanity desperately needs.

VII. The Logos and the Eternal Nature of God

The relationship between Genesis and John also raises an important question concerning eternity.

Genesis begins with the creation of the heavens and the earth. John begins with the existence of the Logos before that creation.

The distinction suggests that the Logos did not begin with the created order or with the succession of events by which human beings measure time.

John's declaration does not describe the Logos as existing for an extraordinarily long period before creation. Rather, it places Him outside the category of beings that came into existence.

John's identification of the Logos as God, together with his declaration that all created things came into existence through Him, establishes that the Word possesses the eternal existence belonging to God alone.

Psalm 90:2 declares:

"Before the mountains were brought forth, or ever thou hadst formed the earth and the world, even from everlasting to everlasting, thou art God."

The eternal existence of God is not dependent upon creation. Neither is the eternal existence of the Logos.

Theologians have long considered whether God's eternity should be understood as an eternal present, in which He does not experience time through the succession of past, present, and future as created beings do.

Scripture does not provide a complete philosophical explanation of God's relationship to time. Nevertheless, Genesis 1 and John 1 establish that the Creator existed before the created order—and therefore before time as we know it—and that the Logos shares that eternal divine existence.

The Word did not begin when Elohim spoke creation into existence.

The Word already was.

VIII. The Word Became Flesh — The Creator Enters His Creation

Although our principal examination concerns John 1:1–5, the full significance of the passage becomes unmistakable in John 1:14:

"And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth."

John now identifies the eternal Logos as the One who entered human history through the Incarnation.

The Word who existed before creation became flesh.

The divine Agent through whom the heavens and earth were made entered the very world He had created.

This is not merely the appearance of another prophet or messenger from God. It is the entrance of the eternal Son into the created order.

John's declaration is especially remarkable because it does not suggest that the Logos ceased to be God when He became flesh. Rather, the eternal Son assumed genuine humanity while retaining His divine nature.

The One who was with God in the beginning entered human history as Jesus Christ. The Creator became part of His creation without surrendering His identity as Creator.

The connection between Genesis and John therefore extends beyond creation into redemption.

In Genesis, Elohim brings light into darkness through His Word.

In John, that same eternal Word enters a world darkened by sin to reveal the Father and provide eternal life.

Jesus later declares:

"I am the light of the world: he that followeth me shall not walk in darkness, but shall have the light of life." (John 8:12)

The declaration connects directly with John's opening description of the Logos as the source of life and light.

The One through whom light came into existence now offers the light of life to humanity.

The Creator has become the Redeemer.

IX. The Unity of Creation and Redemption

The opening chapters of Genesis describe the creation of a world that God repeatedly declares good.

Yet Genesis 3 records humanity's rebellion and the entrance of sin and death into human experience.

The creation that began in goodness becomes the setting for God's unfolding work of redemption.

John's Gospel reveals that the same eternal Logos through whom creation came into existence would become central to that redemptive work.

This establishes an extraordinary unity in Scripture.

Creation and redemption are not unrelated divine activities. They are parts of one sovereign purpose.

The Word who brought the universe into existence is the Word who became flesh, revealed the Father, bore the sins of humanity, and accomplished redemption through His death and resurrection.

John 1:11–12 declares:

"He came unto his own, and his own received him not. But as many as received him, to them gave he power to become the sons of God, even to them that believe on his name."

The One through whom humanity was created became the One through whom fallen humanity could be reconciled to God.

This unity of creation and redemption becomes even more remarkable when considered alongside the biblical promise of a new creation.

The opening chapters of Genesis describe the original creation of the heavens and the earth. The closing chapters of Revelation describe a new heaven and a new earth in which the effects of sin and death have been removed.

Revelation 21:5 declares:

"Behold, I make all things new."

The One through whom the original creation came into existence is also the One through whom God's redemptive purposes reach their fulfillment.

Thus, the relationship between Genesis and John reaches far beyond a literary similarity in their opening words.

Genesis reveals the beginning of the created order. John reveals the eternal Person through whom that beginning occurred and through whom God's redemptive purposes would be accomplished.

The same divine Word stands at the center of creation, redemption, and the promised restoration of all things.

X. Conclusion: The Word Who Was Before the Beginning

Genesis 1:1–3 and John 1:1–5 reveal a unified truth concerning the eternal Creator and His divine Word. Genesis declares that Elohim created the heavens and the earth through His sovereign command. John reveals that the Logos already existed when creation began, that He was with God, that He was God, and that everything that came into existence was made through Him.

The distinction between these passages is not one of contradiction but of progressive revelation. Genesis reveals the creative power of God's Word; John identifies the eternal Person through whom creation was accomplished. Genesis describes light entering the darkness of the newly created world; John reveals the Logos as the source of life and the true Light of humanity.

The theological implications are profound. The Logos cannot be a created being, for all created things came into existence through Him. He is not merely an impersonal expression of divine power, for John describes Him as eternally existing with God and as being God Himself. He is the eternal Son, personally distinct from the Father yet fully sharing the divine nature.

John's revelation reaches its extraordinary fulfillment in the Incarnation: *"And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us"* (John 1:14). The eternal Logos, through whom the universe was created, entered His own creation to accomplish the redemption of fallen humanity.

The One who brought light into the darkness at the beginning of creation is the same One who entered the darkness of a fallen world to bring eternal life.

The Word was there before the beginning, the Word brought creation into existence, and the Word assumed human nature to redeem the very humanity He had created.